With or Against Me

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General Audiences

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by Tadd_the_Turtle

Summary

"Poor thing..."

"-get over it, eventually."

"She's crazy. Why bother?"

They just didn't see the situation like Adora saw it. By the end of this meeting, they would.

They have to.

———

Or: After receiving some distressing news, Adora must plead her case to the rebellion during an Alliance Meeting.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Conflict didn’t have to be a bad thing. It could be…productive. Necessary, even.

Conflict is a prerequisite to consensus. Consensus is the bridge to change. Change saves lives.

Fight. Figure it out. Do some good, for once.

More than most, Adora understood the consequences of conflict, but that didn’t mean she also couldn’t manifest that this meeting would be *productive*, that she could convince the others to do what was *necessary*.

Taking her seat at the war table, the plush seat just a touch too soft for her taste, Adora tried as hard as she could to believe her own inner mantra.

Conflict could lead to change.

(Surely, that didn’t mean some damn good luck wouldn’t be nice too.)

The other princesses claimed this wasn’t an intervention, and, for some reason, thought Adora was actually stupid enough to believe that. Sure, she’d spent the last few days laser-focused on nothing else but planning this meeting. It didn’t suddenly make her oblivious. She could still hear their whispering.

“Poor thing...”

“-get over it, eventually.”

“She’s crazy. Why bother?”

They just didn’t see the situation like Adora saw it. By the end of this meeting, they would.

They have to.

Prepared as always, Adora organized her notes in front of her — carefully drafted plans, maps annotated by hand, detailed requests for resources — everything was ready to go, including her.

All that was left was the Alliance's stamp of approval.

"Alright everyone," Queen Angella cleared her throat. "Find your seats, please. I'd like to start on time."

The others shuffled to their rightful places, fake smiles plastered on, taking their seats as actors take to the stage.

Two could play at that game. In her head, Adora had drafted a script of her own, had gone over it so many times that she could perfectly predict how the idle chatter would die out. She already anticipated that the creak of Mermista's chair would be the sound to break that stifled silence as the princess leaned back haphazardly — a cheap show of disinterest that wouldn't fool Adora. Mermista could feign apathy all she wanted if that's what it took to hide her nervousness, the same nervousness that lurked in the rest of the princesses' tight eyes and unmet gazes.

The only one who seemed to be acting 'business as usual' was Angella. After all, the Queen had to keep up appearances (for whose sake, Adora couldn't say, to her growing impatience).

There was no sense of urgency as the meeting took off to a slow, lackadaisical crawl. One bullet point on the agenda to the next, each more boring and inconsequential than the last.

And, yet, somehow, the Alliance members were miraculously more engaged than ever: asking questions, offering their useless input, stalling for time as everyone ignored the only real reason they were there. Even Glimmer was being weirdly helpful driving the conversation, working *with* Angella to steer the conversation away from the She-Ra-sized elephant in the room.

Adora didn't have time for this. She couldn't help but fidget in her seat, waiting, waiting. There wasn't enough *time*-

"Now," The Queen gave a long sigh, and, with a clear hesitancy to her words, addressed the final item on the agenda, "I believe Adora had something to-"

Adora shot up out of her chair, the metal legs scraping against the floor and making the others wince. *Right…don't go off-script*. She mumbled her apologies, wiping her sweaty palms against her pants, trying to summon her courage as Angella's stare dared to dredge all her anxieties up to the surface.

"Your Majesty. Members of the Princess Alliance." (Better to err on the side of formality.) "I have a proposal to put forth that we all need to vote on. Together."

Bullshit. If Adora had it her way? She'd already be on a skiff, or a boat, or her flying steed. Stars, if she had to, she'd have found a way to fly off in a fucking supersonic spaceship that she'd scraped together herself with nothing but scrap metal and superglue — anything, whatever it took, to get where she needed to be.

"Some, um, some concerning news has come to our attention, as I'm sure you all know by now," Adora kept her eyes glued to her script, forcing herself to just read, otherwise she was certain to spiral. "We have confirmation now that a journey to the island would be of great…*strategic value*."

Adora had to bite through that last bit. She hated the idea that something this important could be relegated to just a buzzword.

"If we were to send a team," Adora continued, "To retrieve-"

"A journey to 'the island'? You are talking about *Beast* Island, correct?" Spinnerella asked.

Adora huffed, hands clenching around her notecards a little tighter. As if that was even a question after the message they received from Entrapta. As if Adora could have been talking about *anything* else.

"Yes," Adora spoke slowly. Deliberately. "Beast Island."

“Which is one of the most crazy deadly places on Etheria, right?” (For some reason, Adora kept hearing people use that irksome word — *crazy*.)

Netossa had asked the question. She was slouching back in her chair with the confidence of someone who had already won an argument that they hadn’t started yet.

Frosta took the interruption as her cue to provide an opinion as well (which it wasn’t), probably thinking she was being helpful (also no). “Why would we wanna go there? Isn’t it full of monsters?”

“Like, what exactly do you think the ‘Beast’ part is there for, genius?”

“Now Mermista, was that a kind or constructive statement?”

“Perfuma’s right,” Adora said stiffly. An unsubtle scowl had begun to crack through her otherwise professional facade, a look that deeply implied she couldn’t care less about what Perfuma said. “We should stay on topic. Yes, okay? I am talking about *the* Beast Island. And, no, I don’t care about any myths or rumors.”

“You mean facts?” Glimmer asked. Maybe it came out more accusatory than she intended, because she added, with a little more sympathy in her tone, “I’m sorry, Adora, but nobody that’s gone there has ever returned.”

“We can’t know that for sure.” Adora felt herself grinding her teeth as she tried to keep her cool. She should just fall back on her notes, except…now she’s all out of order. Really, she had planned to get derailed, but not *this* soon.

“As I was trying to say, we can reasonably assume that a rescue mission-” (The others probably would have preferred the term *capture*) “-would result in us gaining invaluable Horde intel. At the very least, we’ll get insight that we won’t be able to get anywhere else.”

"What about Shadow Weaver?" Netossa countered, not noticing the immediate look of dismay on both Bow and Glimmer's faces (because at least they pretended to understand how awful the lady was). "She's just as good a resource. I mean, she was Hordak's second-in-command longer-"

"She doesn't know anything operational within the Horde that's not months old already," Glimmer pointed out, sounding conflicted, like she wasn't supposed to actually be *helping* Adora's case. "There's not a lot to really go by."

(Not to mention, Shadow Weaver was undeniably the absolute *worst*, but who cared about Adora's opinion, right? It only mattered to them if another princess — a real princess — said it.)

Adora's chest began to tighten. It was getting harder to look the Alliance members in the eyes, but she would never convince them if they thought she didn't have the stomach for this mission. If she wasn't good enough to earn their confidence, then she wasn't good enough to save-

"I apologize," Angella's stare bore into Adora, an aggravating, pitying look on her face, "But I'm having a hard time seeing how the potential outcomes outweigh the risks. As much as I understand why you want this mission to proceed, we must consider the danger we put our own people in. We cannot sacrifice a whole team for one person."

"All due respect, your Majesty," Adora said the classic phrase that usually meant something fairly disrespectful was about to come, "We've conducted rescue missions successfully before. Into the heart of the Fright Zone even." (Stop talking, stop talking, stop-) "But I suppose it's different when it's your daughter we're saving, right?"

Nausea threatened to deny her what little access she had left to her already closed-up airways, but Adora refused to take the words back. She didn't regret them. There were far more important priorities to attend to, all of which took precedence over

something as inconsequential as the preservation of her reputation.

"Need I remind you," Angella responded with dwindling patience, "That I did not approve of any mission of the sort. *You* took a team of inexperienced fighters into the depths of enemy territory without my permission and lost someone in the process. Is that what you call a success?"

"Entrapta is fine," Adora argued. "She's happier, not being here." *And I don't blame her,* unfair as it was, went unspoken. "Besides, if we didn't try, you would have turned yourself into the Horde, and you already know we all would've done anything if it meant getting you back."

The others shared their nods of agreement, but the brief unity was only a fragile thing, swiftly broken as soon as the hammer of reality swung down on their heads. The words 'Beast Island' and 'rescue mission' simply weren't meant to go together.

But Adora knew she could convince them; she just needed more time — time, time, *time*.

Desperate times.

Desperate measures.

"I understand if you're worried about losing an entire team. Send me on my own then." (And, against her better judgment, because this required a steely determination with no room for old feelings bleeding into this,) Adora tacked on, "Your Majesty, you know what it's like to be willing to sacrifice yourself for someone, just because of how much you care."

Then, Adora's throat finally did close around the word 'care' and she had to inhale sharply, shock her lungs back to life, before she could push through with her pleas. "Shouldn't I be allowed to take that same risk? Don't I get a choice at all? I know I can handle this mission, if you would let-"

“Can you?” Glimmer asked, and, with just two words, all of Adora’s vulnerability turned ice cold, into venom.

As if Glimmer was worried. As if she *cared*. Adora couldn’t bear it — because if Glimmer actually cared, she would’ve been on her side from the start, would’ve teleported them halfway to Beast Island by now. She wouldn’t have dragged Adora to her mother in the first place (quite literally, dragged, as Adora could barely stand on her own when they’d learned what happened).

“Can I…*what*, Glimmer?”

“Can you handle it?” Glimmer finally leaned forward, fixing Adora with a stare that harbored a strange mix between frustration and concern. “Because, honestly Adora, I have never seen you like this before. You’re not eating. You’re not sleeping. You’re not listening to reason. You're not focusing on the important-”

“I am *plenty* focused.” Up until that moment, Adora had fought (maybe unsuccessfully) to maintain some semblance of civility, but it all went out the window as soon as Glimmer struck that age-old nerve. Her fists slammed into the table as she made one thing very clear: “Catra isn’t a distraction!”

Like a broken spell, the name sent the room into silence. No one had dared to call Adora out for it, not directly. Adora hadn’t been able to bring herself to say it. Not *directly*. And, yet, there it was, finally. The She-Ra-sized elephant in the room. The real reason they were there in the first place.

Catra.

It was always Catra, wasn’t it?

“Maybe we should take a break?” Bow cut in. “Understandably, emotions are running high. We should all take a moment to-”

“No,” Adora shook her head. Nothing against Bow, but- “No. There is no more waiting around, sitting on our asses. Do any of you actually care that someone’s life is in danger? Or are we picking

and choosing now who deserves the high-and-mighty *Princess Alliance's* time?"

Never once, not even in the Horde, had Adora spat out the rebellion's name with such contempt, but she couldn't help it. In the back of her mind, there was that little child soldier shrieking and shouting, banging her training staff against her skull. '*See?! See what they're really like!*'

"Bow is right," Angella said. "You need to take a moment to calm down."

The sound slipped out of Adora's throat, the laughter. "Calm down? Your majesty, I assure you, I will be plenty calm once I know that you, certainly of all people, aren't going to just sit there and sentence someone to their death."

Because that's what all this really was, wasn't it? They could try and live in denial all they wanted, but Adora didn't share the luxury of deluding herself into thinking this was an *exile* instead of an *execution*.

"I know this is not the answer you were hoping for," Angella started, choosing her words carefully. "Understand it brings me no joy to say it, either. But Hordak did what he did on his own accord, to his own Force Captain. I am not the one who sent Catra to Beast Island."

"But you are the one who will sit on your throne like a coward and let her die there!" If Adora was burning bridges, then let the gasoline pour. "I can expect as much from Hordak. Forgive me if I thought the rebellion would be any different."

"You're comparing us to the Horde?" Frosta asked in disbelief. "We're literally nothing like those monsters!"

"Monsters?" Adora echoed back, another ghost of a laugh leaving her lips. "Well, then I guess it takes one to know one."

“Are you implying something about us?” Mermista asked, eyes narrowed.

“No, not at all,” Adora shrugged in an overly-casual way. “But you’re all certainly implying something about me. I mean, I guess I would know a thing or two about monsters, considering I *was* one. Right?”

“That’s not fair,” Glimmer immediately shot back. “You’re different!”

“*I’m* different?” Adora pointed at herself, her gold brace glinting in the light. “Or am I just useful to all of you?”

“That’s not-”

“Some mystical space lady says I’m a princess, so now I get special treatment? Is that it?”

“You’re a good person, Adora.” Bow said — and, *sure*, maybe he saw it as a compliment, and not a back-handed jab at the people Adora didn’t dare call *family* in their presence. “You want to do good and help people. Not everyone is like that in the Horde. Force Captains especially-”

“I was a Force Captain, in case you forgot.” There were a few shocked faces, some murmurs. Though it was common knowledge that Adora came from the Horde, the extent of her involvement conveniently wasn’t mentioned much (or ever). “I was supposed to lead the raid on Thaymore that day. I would have, gladly, if I hadn’t found the sword. I was *just* as capable as any other Horde soldier.”

“Yes,” Angella said, agreeing with her for the first time all day. “You *were* capable. But you did not harm anyone that day.” (*Of course you did, you*-) “You chose to reject that life.” (*Reject them*.) “Catra did not. There is a difference. I will not let you risk your life for a budding war criminal.”

The edge of Adora's lips twitched up into a dangerous smile, and for a moment they could almost see it — not their friend, but the merciless Force Captain who'd been fighting her way to the top since birth.

"Let me?" Adora echoed, amused and tired and burning with that righteous anger. The way she clenched her fist against the table made her arm brace glisten in the light.

"Yes," Angella stood her ground. "*Let* you. In case you've forgotten, when we first met, you swore your allegiance to this rebellion. To Brightmoon. To your Queen."

Then, Angella actually stood, rising to her full height, looming over all parties at the table.

"Would you forsake your oath?"

"Queen Angella…" Adora paused. She'd never done well under the glares of her superiors. Her resolve had never quite hardened to that disapproving tone. Anger ebbing away to something much smoother, much sadder, Adora felt her muscles unwind themselves. She breathed in deeply, letting the air back out slowly, before finally saying, "I'm…I'm sorry."

The tension dispelled. Adora would be forgiven for her outburst, for her insolence. All would be-

"I'm sorry, but I made a promise to Catra first."

-right.

The other princesses were quick to protest, but Angella silenced them with a hand. Her regal glare held fast, but there was an unmistakable note of grief to it.

"Tread carefully, Adora. You are digging yourself into a hole that I'm not sure you can climb out of."

Adora offered Angella a shrug, the only thing she had left to give, "Better that than digging Catra's grave."

They weren't getting it. They weren't ever going to get it, no matter how many ways Adora said it (without having to *say it*).

She still tried, one last time. "Catra isn't a bad person. You just don't know her. None of you." (*Not like I do*.)

"We know that she led the siege on Brightmoon," Angella said. "We know she has repeatedly attempted to thwart our efforts. She ruined Princess Prom." (Frosta huffed at the reminder.) "She kidnapped Bow, kidnapped *Glimmer*."

"Catra did her job. It's not her fault if she's good at it too." And if there was a hint of pride there, in Adora's voice, then so be it.

"She has hurt *you* on multiple occasions," Angella said, defending Adora just as fiercely as she did her own daughter moments ago. It was enough to strike Adora in that soft emotional center, the one she'd tried so hard to barricade away with anger at the start of all this — alas, her walls were already down. "Are we expected to show her such an extreme kindness when she has given us not even the slightest in return?"

"Yes!" Adora threw her hands up, voice shaky, desperation taking hold, "Because if Catra has done all of that…just so she can hurt *me*…and you aren't willing to save her when I am the one *begging* you to," Adora breathed in shakily, "Then can you even imagine how much pain I'd be in if I lost her for good?"

Adora hated it. The stares. The pity. The realization on their stupid, naive faces — finally — of what this all really meant.

But good soldiers don't show emotion. They don't crack. And they certainly don't-

"I am asking for your help…please, your Majesty."

It wasn't an impossible ask. Angella knew that just as well as Adora. They'd beaten the odds before. Who says Beast Island would be any different?

It didn't make it any less of an impossible decision. If Angella said yes, then she undermined her own authority by giving in to Adora's commands, in front of the other Alliance members no less (who certainly, were a vote cast, might still hold their reservations).

If Angella said no, though, then she risked losing her best fighter, She-Ra.

And she risked losing Adora. A price that she feared would exceed all else.

So, Angella did the only thing she knew to do. She placed the burden back onto Adora's shoulders by giving *her* a choice — an impossible choice.

"Catra's fate is not in our hands anymore. This Alliance will not support a mission to Beast island and that is final. Furthermore, Adora, if you plan to walk out these palace doors, then I promise that you will not be welcomed back through them. Do you understand?"

Was that a threat that Adora was actually supposed to take seriously? Or merely a bluff? Adora couldn't help but lean towards the first, judging by the way the princesses seemed ready to spring from their seats at any moment, ready to drag her back to her room kicking and screaming.

Conflict *without* consensus, it is, then.

"I understand, your Majesty."

See, the Queen might have thought she was giving Adora an impossible decision, but Adora wasn't stupid and she wasn't naive. She was the prodigal child, the youngest Force Captain in the

history of the Horde, the would-be war hero — and she had a plan.

Glass shattered as her shield burst through the window behind her. The others hardly had time to understand what happened, with only a moment to register how her now-bare forearm extended in the shadow of a throw: proof of her malicious compliance.

Then, at a dead sprint, Adora jumped out of the window.

The group shot out of their seats to follow, but Glimmer got there first, teleporting instantly to the ledge. She almost expected to see an Adora-shaped splat on the ground below her, but quickly realized she needed to look *up*.

Glimmer's eyes followed the flying horse, merely a pink and white blurb speeding away into the distance, with a gold rider on top, long blonde hair whipping in the wind.

The princess's fingers twitched. It wasn't too far of a teleport. Moving objects weren't the worst targets. If Glimmer focused, she could make it, easily.

"She's fucking crazy," The princess whispered instead, and retreated back to her room with Bow at her heels.

End Notes

This one has been sitting in the WIP pile for eons, lads. Basically my take of what might've happened if Catra was actually sent to Beast Island in season 3, instead of the Waste.

Some of this was me playing around with writing style, the rest was just straight up self-indulgence. I mean, the ending was definitely very different on the first draft, but once I got the mental image of Adora yeeting herself out a window Captain-America-style? Yeah, there was no going back.

Lessons learned? Free indirect discourse is your best friend and there is never such thing as too many parenthesis.

Let me know what y'all thought in the comments! Always appreciate y'all :)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!